trade, investment, and foreign aid. Now China is moving to extend its global reach through multilateral institutions via the G20 and the BRICS.

The prominence of the BRICS in the G20 process has also been useful for China to deal collectively with the international political pressures imposed on itself. At their onset, the G20 summits were seen as forums to put pressure on China, as others demanded that China revalue the RMB and contribute to financial rescue efforts to benefit the Western economies hit hard by the global financial crisis. Being included and put on the spot as the second-most important member of the G20 process (behind the United States), the Chinese government has felt wary of the demands and the pressure, as it has had to abandon its skeptical rule-taker position regarding the issues of global financial governance and step up its game in addressing global reforms.[50]

Although China now has clearly moved beyond the phase in which some scholars have labeled it "reluctant to lead,"[51] concerns remain among Chinese leaders that the country would be trapped into the state of *pengsha*, wherein China would be placed in the position of sharing the costs of global reforms without being given actual influence in the process.[52] Chinese elites have often felt that China has sometimes been a victim of the hierarchical, U.S.-led order and should resist pressure to integrate more deeply to avoid paying high costs.[53] China has needed to cultivate the space and foreign policy instruments where it can expand what Benjamin Cohen calls "power-as-autonomy," which is the ability of one state to avoid direct pressure from another; that is, "it means, not allowing other states to influence you."[54] This would include the power to avoid pressure and sanctions, even as China engages in the politics of global financial governance using the BRICS as its collaborators and becomes a key member of global forums.[55]

Fund and Control the BRICS Process Through Its Resource Dominance

The third source of China's motivation to cooperate with the BRICS is simply that it can afford to do so. With large financial resources at its disposal, it can also afford its individual "outside option" to control the BRICS' collective strategy. As discussed in Chapter 2, the exceptional growth of the Chinese economy in the last thirty years, particularly since the 2000s, has created an ever increasing gap between China's economic